million Afghan refugees, who lived under tents in Pakistan's North-West Frontier Province and were regularly sent back to Afghanistan to shoot down Soviet helicopters and blow up tanks and trucks. The impact of its defeat in Afghanistan on Moscow's "Evil Empire," as Reagan called the Soviet Union, helped to accelerate its collapse by the end of 1989. As long as Zia armed enough mujahideen to succeed in carrying out that highest Cold War priority for the White House, nothing dreadful he did, or failed to do, at home evoked negative reactions from Washington. He was thus left to sow seeds of global terror that would threaten the entire world little more than a decade after his own C-130 presidential plane went down in flames near Bahawalpur in Punjab on 17 August 1988.

No one ever claimed responsibility for the death of Zia's planeful of generals as well as the U.S. ambassador to Pakistan, Arnold Raphel, and one American general, both of whom had joined the flight at Zia's urgent insistence. No FBI investigation of the crash was ever made public. Most Pakistanis believe that a gift box of mangoes loaded onto the plane minutes before takeoff contained deadly poison nerve gas that killed both pilots, and that the CIA was responsible. Some believe that either the Soviet KGB or Afghan Intelligence (KAKH) had strong enough motives and capability to do the job. Still others think it was the Indian cabinet's intelligence bureau, the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), that assassinated Zia to expedite the regime change in Islamabad that swiftly followed. On 2 December 1988, elections held throughout Pakistan by its new president, Ghulam Ishaq Khan, brought Benazir Bhutto's PPP to power. She was sworn in as Pakistan's first female prime minister.

Four years before Benazir's rise to premier power, Indira Gandhi had been gunned down in her own garden by two of her trusted Sikh bodyguards. The tragic assassination of Nehru's daughter on 31 October 1984 was triggered by the Indian army's "Operation Bluestar," a tank attack launched against Amritsar's Golden Temple that Gandhi had authorized early that June. Armed Sikh extremists had taken control of the temple and its sacred tower repository of Sikh scripture, demanding a separate Sikh state of Khalistan (Land of the Pure), humiliating Indira Gandhi and her administration with their taunts and treacherous challenges. She should have known better than to send tanks into that most sacred temple compound, but it was an election year, and her Congress Party MPs feared that if she continued to look too weak to crush the Khalistan extremists occupying the temple, they would all surely be defeated.